Fading scaffolds

Removing support as students become secure

Use fading to move students beyond dependence on prompts, models or frames. Decide which support to remove from evidence of what students can now do.

How to do it well

1 Identify the remaining dependency. Observe which part of the task still requires the model, cue or teacher prompt.

2 Select the next reduction. Remove one support that successful performance suggests is no longer needed.

3 Give a comparable attempt. Hold the task demand steady so you can interpret the effect of the reduction.

4 Respond to the attempt. Keep, reduce or briefly restore a specific cue according to accuracy and reasoning.

5 Hand over the process. Students plan and complete the task independently, then revisit it later and in a varied context.

What this sounds like

“You no longer need the sentence opening. Keep the evidence checklist for this attempt; next time we will try without that too.”

Classroom example. For an extended response, the teacher first removes the sentence starters but keeps the evidence checklist. After pupils can explain the links independently, the checklist is reduced too. When one student loses the structure, only the necessary cue returns. Support changes with the observed barrier rather than disappearing for the whole class at once.

Top tips that make the technique work

Separate support from difficulty. Keep content familiar while removing a cue, then introduce variation once independence is secure.

Fade a specific feature. Remove the sentence opening, checklist item or worked step that the student no longer needs.

Watch for hidden dependence. Successful copying from a visible model does not establish that the student can choose the approach alone.

Restore the minimum cue. If success drops, reinstate the smallest support that repairs the barrier.

Include later independence. Return after a delay so the task is not supported by immediate memory of the model.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Make the withdrawal staged and purposeful.	Keeping a frame permanently for every task.
Check the decisions students make without prompts.	Removing all support on the same date for every student.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Fading Support | DistillED - Provide Scaffolds for Difficult Tasks